MAKE IT DO · FREE SHEET

What things cost the year you were born

1959

IN 1959	THE RECORD	TODAY	IN OUR HOUSE
A pound of white bread per pound	20¢	**$1.87** per pound	
A dozen eggs per dozen	53¢	**$4.25** per dozen	
Half a gallon of milk delivered to the door	51¢	**$2.03** half a gallon, at the store	
A pound of butter per pound	75¢	**$4.76** per pound	
A pound of round steak per pound	$1.07	**$8.86** per pound	
A pound of bacon per pound	66¢	**$7.02** per pound	
A pound of coffee per pound	78¢	**$8.18** per pound	
Five pounds of sugar 5-pound bag	57¢	**$5.12** 5 pounds	
Ten pounds of potatoes 10-pound bag	63¢	**$9.63** 10 pounds	
A gallon of gas regular, with taxes	30¢	**$3.26** regular unleaded	
A stamp for a letter first-class, first ounce	4¢	**82¢** Forever stamp	

IN 1959	THE RECORD	TODAY	IN OUR HOUSE
An hour's pay at the federal minimum from Mar. 1, 1956	$1.00	**$7.25** federal minimum since 2009	

THE NAMES IN THE HOSPITAL NURSERY, 1959

Girls: Mary, Susan, Linda, Karen, Donna. **Boys:** Michael, David, James, John, Robert.

One dollar in 1959 buys about what **$11.06** buys today (consumer price index, 2025 average). The last column is yours: write in what it cost in your house.

Where every number comes from. U.S. Bureau of the Census, Historical Statistics of the United States, Colonial Times to 1970, Part 1, p. 213, series E 188, 189, 192, 193, 194, 195, 197, 200, 202 (retail food prices, BLS); U.S. Energy Information Administration, Annual Energy Review 2011 (DOE/EIA-0384(2011)), Table 5.24 Retail Motor Gasoline and On-Highway Diesel Fuel Prices, Leaded Regular gasoline, U.S. city average, Nominal, AER 2011 Table 5.24 web/spreadsheet version (all years); printed p. 173 shows selected years only; United States Postal Service, Historian, "Rates for Domestic Letters Since 1863" (September 2021), Table "Postage in Cents, per Ounce" (effective dates), p. 1 (single-page PDF); U.S. Department of Labor, Wage and Hour Division, History of Federal Minimum Wage Rates Under the Fair Labor Standards Act, 1938-2009 (1938 Act column). Today: U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics average prices, 2025 average; USPS 2026.

From the Make It Do film *Everyday Life in 1950s America, in Real Color Film*